

Episode 137: Once Upon a Time... 81 – 1995 Part 1 – Rubble and Collapse in January

I've been maintaining early sleep, early rise as much as possible all summer. Wake up around 4-5 AM and start work. Eat breakfast around 7, then home work again all morning. External meetings from afternoon. Sleep around 11 PM—this lifestyle has settled wonderfully.

This morning time is truly pleasant. Quiet, head is clear, work seems twice as efficient (←by our company standards).

Plus amazingly, excess weight has started decreasing bit by bit. Apparently early rising and activity, then proper breakfast when hunger begins, works well. Everyone should try it.

What I experience through such early rising is sunrise time progression. July-August skies were bright after 4 AM, but this September it's around 5 AM before getting bright. Ah, already "autumn equinox." After "autumn equinox," sunrise gets considerably later, and evening sunset gradually earlier too.

Weather will finally cool down, truly feeling like autumn. Heading toward a somewhat lonely season.

Now then.

January 1995. *Dragon Ball Z Movie: Fusion Reborn!!* Goku and Vegeta had all storyboards completed and work progressing reasonably smoothly.

Theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* gives us makers an image of "harder battles" compared to TV series. Actually, stronger enemies appeared each time with increasingly hard battles.

Intense combat, crumbling mountains and buildings, explosions, and fires. While certainly one of theatrical *Dragon Ball Z*'s attractions, this tended to make screen atmosphere heavy and dark each time.

"Bright, pastel-like colour tones," said Director Yamauchi. This *Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta* differed from previous theatrical versions, becoming a work with brighter, more comical tastes pushed more forward.

The demon world where innocent Janemba created barriers became a bright pastel space with countless mysterious colourful spheres floating in the air. At its centre sat cream-coloured fluffy Janemba, easily handling Goku's persistent attacks.

Meanwhile, the earthly realm where the dead revived causing chaos was also never drawn realistically—character outlines were bounded by thick outer lines, with animation and colours all made comical. While previous theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* had realistic explosions and smoke, in this earthly realm these were all manga-like too. Unified in bright pastels.

For several recent works, theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* "protagonists" were Goten and Trunks little kid combo. While little kids were certainly active this time too, I think they visually clearly separated realistic battle demon world from comical-touch earthly realm to clarify that story axis and main battles were Goku and Vegeta.

Work progressing toward editing and dubbing like that, at dawn on January 17th, a massive earthquake struck Osaka, Kobe, and Awaji. The Great Hanshin Earthquake.

Those tremors reached distant Tokyo, and though only intensity 1, I woke from that shaking and learnt from TV news upon waking that "something terrible seems to be happening." From then I was glued to TV. Streets on fire, collapsed buildings, highways, houses, shopping districts. I was shocked by footage delivered one after another. Well past departure time and beyond, I continued staring at news screens.

Man, real rubble footage. We regularly do rubble, building collapse, and disaster screens in anime including *Dragon Ball*, but seeing such things actually happening in reality creates quite complex feelings. I was made to realise reality's weight.

Witnessing that earthquake footage, honestly I thought "I don't want to create realistic rubble and collapse imagery." And if children who experienced the earthquake watched and there were realistic such scenes, even in anime, wouldn't they feel bad?

Thinking that way, "Ah, this theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* was good to make with bright screens and many comical parts!" That's what I thought in January 1995.

(10.09.21)